Initiative Document

One of the things that makes collaboration work on well-run agile teams is **alignment**. You'll know you're on a well-aligned team when everybody knows what they're building together, why they're building it and what their ultimate goal is. This allows everybody to work on their pieces of the development in parallel without losing sight of the overall goals.

In practice, though, agile teams tend to face communication problems. Often, teams can end up communicating with each other entirely through Jira tickets rather than coming together around a common understanding of the needs of the team and the users.

When everyone on a team has a different idea of what, and why they're building a feature, it can become very difficult to coordinate, build and move forward as a team. Arguments about "the most important" parts of a feature to build can drag on and on because nobody knows what makes something important or unimportant.

The Initiative Document can **help teams understand** exactly what they're all working on and what outcomes they hope to achieve. While it's more typical for product managers or product owners to create and own feature strategy, as a designer or researcher you may find yourself in a position where having the team fill out an Initiative Document together can clarify a lot of things about the features you're expected to build.

This template was developed by Adam Thomas (**website**), a product management expert who frequently consults with teams to help them make better product decisions.

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Remember, the Goal Is One Page. Keep Cutting until You Get There.

Abstract

For this section, you'll need to sit and write about what you are trying to achieve, who is it for, what is it for, who is affected by the work, what success looks like, the history of the team, etc. This section is where you'll spend most of your time. However, it's the key to understanding what you are spending all of this effort to build.

This is the paragraph that outlines the work, and it needs to be short. Someone should be able to read it and repeat it. When writing the abstract, one technique to consider is the **protostrategy method** from Chris Butler — build a five-page outline, then cut that down to one page, and eventually, to a single paragraph. After completing the other four sections, you'll come back to the abstract and finalize it.

Objectives

How does this initiative tie into the overall product strategy? Your project should have a direct line to the company's objectives and goals.

To get started, you'll need to reread the company's product mission/vision/strategy docs and relate your project to these overarching themes. Do not try to force a connection between your abstract and the company objectives. This should serve as a check to see if this is worth doing. And if it isn't, you should stop here and make your case as to why this is a waste of time.

Resources

How are we going to staff this? Who is going to do what?

You want to collect all of this information in one easy-to-share place. You don't want any surprises when the actual work gets going. Begin by looking at what (and who) is available and start talking to the folks involved to make sure they have an understanding of what's at stake and what you need to get it done. Also — make sure you are clear about who needs to make decisions, and who needs to stay aware. However, remember it is their resources that you are going to need — they can say no.

Continued on the next page — we have some cutting to do :)

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Success/Survival

What does success look like? What about failure?

To start determining the answers to these questions, look at the abstract, and start pulling the numbers. Make sure you add qualitative constraints as well, what are the third rails of this project? Think about survival, failure, and success and explain it in terms anyone can understand. Describe exactly when to pull the plug [think about the resources you are using], keep going [what are some near term signs of success] or double down [success metrics].

Time Horizon

How long will this take? Even better — when can people expect answers? Leadership will want to know how you are going to use the resources available to complete your project when they should check-in and on what timeline.

If you are at an "Agile" shop — start with an estimate of how many sprints the work will take. Try to remember Parkinson's Law (things take as much time as you let them) and balance it with the Law of Slack (we never finish things on time). You are never going to nail this, but an estimate will help folks make a "go, no-go" decision.

A Few Notes...

- Meeting notes and retrospective notes are great to add as the project goes on. This can function as a complete log of the project.
- It's fine if different disciplines take copies of this doc and use it for their own purposes, remember this is an initiative document. If teams are taking it back and using it, it's a good thing!
- This document is alive. Take it with you to your meetings. Lead with it. When people are sick of talking about it, you are about halfway there.

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Example of a Complete Initiative Document

Abstract

What you are trying to achieve?

Informed is the #1 tool for online sellers who want to make more money and stay ahead of the competition. As the current first mover in the space, they have helped customers sell upwards of 500,000,000 Gross Merchandise Value (GMV) per month. They, however, see that the customer isn't really informed about how to use the service, and as a result, for all but the most successful customers, most feel unsure, and don't explore more than the basics. This isn't a professional attitude, and makes users miss out on the other important tools Informed has to offer, like automated discounting on small and light (S&L) that can potentially save them thousands of dollars per month.

Our hypothesis is that by simplifying the onboarding experience through a "helper" feature, we'll be able to make the customer more comfortable with other tools and increase their GMV.

Objectives

How does this tie into the product strategy?

- Make customers aware of the tools available to them → Company mission "More empowered sellers"
- Increase feature utilization over time → Objective for onboarding team: How might we make the customer more comfortable with the tools in front of them

Success/Survival

What does success look like? Failure?

- Increase in the delta of customer feature usage by customer journey stage by 10% per stage (the customer should get more comfortable/ more comfortable with tools)
- Increase in the GMV for users over time
- Pivot — if customers see less than 5% change

Resources

How are we going to staff this?

- Product development team — Architect, Engineer (3x), PM, Designer, Marketer
- Stakeholders — Leadership team (aware) Director of Product/Eng (Advocates)

Timeline

How long will this take?

- MVP — less than 3 sprints.
- If successful — quarter to productionize.

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Example of a Complete Initiative Document

Abstract

What you are trying to achieve?

Objectives

How does this tie into the product strategy?

Success/Survival

What does success look like? Failure?

Resources

How are we going to staff this?

Timeline

How long will this take?

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Methods of using this template are taught in our online course **Agile Methods for UX Design**. Make full use of this template and learn more about working on agile teams by signing up for it today.

Agile Methods for UX Design

Intermediate Course

Agile, in one form or another, has taken over the software development world and is poised to move into almost every other industry. The problem is that a lot of teams and organizations that call themselves "agile" don't seem to have much in common with each other. This can be extremely confusing to a new team member, especially if you've previously worked on an "agile" team that had an entirely different definition of "agility!"

The **Agile Methods for UX Design** course aims to show you what true agility is and how closely agile methodologies can map to design. You will learn both the theory, and the real-world implementation of agile, its different flavors, and how you can work with different versions of agile teams.

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